

THE RUN OF SHOW

≈ 8-10 MIN · THREE BEATS · REPRODUCIBLE ACTIVITY

A reproducible protocol for reactivating Picabia's *Manifeste cannibale dada* as an event in a seminar. Instead of summarizing the text, the facilitator **does what the text orders**. Anyone can run it. In **red bold**, the lines read aloud.

1

1 · OPENING IN CHARACTER · REENACTMENT · ~2 MIN

DO WHAT THE TEXT ORDERS

Enter without explaining anything and read the opening as a command:

“YOU ARE ALL ACCUSED; STAND UP. THE SPEAKER CANNOT ADDRESS YOU UNLESS YOU ARE STANDING.”

Get the class to **stand** and read the standing litany: “stand as for the Marseillaise... the Russian anthem... *God save the King*... the flag... and finally stand before DADA.” The text ranks Dada with the anthem and the flag and, in passing, **accuses** the audience: “loving anything out of snobbery, as long as it costs a lot.”

Sit the class with “Have you all sat down again? So much the better; now you will listen more closely,” and **break character**. In two minutes the audience has already been turned into a commodity: that is exactly what is about to be read.

2

2 · THE READING · CANNIBALISM → CONSUMPTION · ~5 MIN

UNDO WHAT JUST HAPPENED

a) **The chain of equivalences**. The manifesto doesn't argue, it **chains**. “Penned in like serious oysters,” then from seriousness to death (“serious unto death”; “you die a hero or an idiot, which is the same”), from death to money (“only money doesn't die, it just goes travelling”), from money to God and honour (“the man who has money is an honourable man”), and from honour to the obscene body (“honour is bought and sold like the arse... you will stink worse than cow dung”). Serious = death = money = God = honour = shit: all of bourgeois culture reduced to a single digestion.

b) **The litany of nothing.** Then Dada swallows it all and excretes no nutrient: “it smells of nothing, it is nothing, nothing, nothing.” Run the list (hopes, paradises, idols, politicians, heroes, artists, religions), answering **nothing** to each. Pure cannibalism: consuming to **annul**, not to transform.

c) **The self-cannibal turn.** In the last line Dada eats its own critique: “whistle, shout, smash my face in... in three months my friends and I will sell you our paintings for a few francs.” The anti-avant-garde that denied money and seriousness **walks back onto the market**. Negation becomes a commodity: here **cannibalism** turns into **consumption**.

d) **The contrast: Andrade.** Compare with Oswald de Andrade’s *Cannibalist Manifesto* (1928): anthropophagy devours the colonizer in order to **metabolize** him and make something new (Brazilian modernism). Same decade, opposite digestion: Picabia consumes and does not digest; Andrade digests to **transform**.

CANNIBALISM → CALIBANISM → ANTHROPOPHAGY → CONSUMPTION

That is the arc of the course, and Picabia’s last line is the hinge toward **consumption**.

3

3 · INTERACTION + CLOSING · ~3 MIN

CALL-AND-RESPONSE LITANY

Call and response. Run the litany again, now with the class: the facilitator says the noun (“your idols,” “your heroes,” “your artists,” “your religions”) and everyone answers “**nothing!**”. The room **enacts** the emptying instead of hearing it.

Landing in the present. Close by returning to the sale of the paintings: where does that line fall today? NFT-art, the brand, the museum. The avant-garde that sold itself “for a few francs” is already our art market.

Pose the **discussion questions** (next page) and show the web piece, where the manifesto devours itself as you scroll.

MANIFESTE CANNIBALE DADA

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (CLOSING)

- 01 If Dada “is nothing, nothing, nothing,” why does it need the audience on its feet? Can an anti-avant-garde negate everything without turning into a ritual, that is, just one more anthem?
- 02 The last line sells the paintings. Is Picabia cynical, or is it a lucid critique that every avant-garde ends up as merchandise? Where does that line fall today: NFT-art, the museum, the brand?
- 03 Picabia consumes and does not digest; Andrade digests in order to transform. Which of the two “cannibalisms” better describes Latin America’s relationship to European culture? Or do we need both?

Francis Picabia, “Manifeste cannibale dada.” Read by André Breton at the 3rd Dada soirée, Théâtre de l’Œuvre, Paris, 27 March 1920. Published in Dadaphone no. 7.

Oswald de Andrade, “Cannibalist Manifesto,” Revista de Antropofagia, São Paulo, 1928.

Activity designed by Adri M · SPAN 550B, UBC.

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